

Coming out

The term “coming out” is used when a person shares their sexual or gender identity with others. For the person who is coming out, it can be both daunting and rewarding to be honest and open about who they are and how they really feel.

Everyone comes out about something

Coming out is usually understood as a person telling friends and family that they identify as LGBTQ+. But in a broader sense, it means revealing something to another person. It is usually something important to a person’s identity, for example, their religious or political beliefs, or an event from their past. Sharing this information can make people feel vulnerable, and, because of this, many individuals take a long time to decide when and how to come out. For LGBTQ+ people, coming out ultimately allows them to embrace how they feel.

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◀ 206–207 Sexuality

◀ 208–209 Different sexual identities

◀ 210–211 Attraction



Ways of coming out

Everybody comes out in different ways. Many people come out to someone less critical to their life before telling family and friends. Others prefer to tell their parents and closest friends first. Some tell the people in their lives one by one, while others choose to come out to everyone at the same time. It’s possible for a person to be out to some people but not others—for example, out at school but not at home, or vice versa.

It can be useful to find out how family or friends feel about different sexualities in advance, to try to find out what reaction to expect. Some people may be more surprised than others, or take longer to absorb such new information. Whoever they are, the first person to know should always be someone trusted who will respond with kindness and acceptance.

▷ Everyone is different

Sometimes people come out in conversations, letters, or emails; others choose to come out with a party.



PARENT TIPS

If your teen comes out to you

- Discuss people who are LGBTQ+ openly and positively, so your teen knows you will be okay if they come out to you.
- It may be a shock at first, but try to stay calm and praise them for sharing. Your teen is still the same person.
- Teens may not be able to explain fully their own feelings at first. Be patient and allow them time to figure things out.
- There are many organizations that provide support for both parents of LGBTQ+ teens and LGBTQ+ teens themselves.